

WHAT NOBODY TELLS YOU BEFORE YOUR **FIRST DELIVERY**

The pay gaps, gear regrets, and rookie mistakes real US delivery riders wish they'd known on Day 1. Pulled straight from the road, not a training manual.

NEW RIDER TRAPS

VETERAN BURNOUT

GEAR THAT HOLDS UP

CROSS-PLATFORM RISKS

22%

OF NYC
DELIVERY
WORKERS
REPORT BEING
INJURED ON
THE JOB

28+

CHECKLIST
ITEMS ACROSS
NEW &
VETERAN RIDER
PAIN POINTS

4

MAJOR
PLATFORMS
COVERED,
INCLUDING
DOORDASH,
UBER EATS,
GRUBHUB, AND
INSTACART

Most rider advice is written for someone else's day.

This isn't generic gig-work advice. Every page is built from what riders themselves report on DoorDash, Uber Eats, Grubhub, and Instacart forums, plus city-level labor data. It's the stuff that actually catches people off guard. **New riders** get blindsided by pay structures and safety risks nobody explained. **Veteran riders** get worn down by things that only show up after month three. This guide covers both.



New Riders

What surprises riders in their first 90 days, including pay traps, app rules, and hazards nobody warns you about before you clock in.



Veteran Riders

What wears riders down after the honeymoon period. Burnout, shrinking pay, and the financial blind spots that compound over time.



Gear Reality Check

What riders say they wish they'd bought sooner, and what cheap gear actually costs you in the long run.

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New Rider Reality Check

☐ Don't trust the app's delivery clock blindly

Many first-time riders report getting marked "late" on orders even while rushing. The app's time estimates often don't reflect real traffic, parking, or building access delays. A late mark or two in your first week doesn't mean you're doing it wrong.

Know this going in so one bad timer doesn't make you quit on Day 2.

☐ Base pay can be lower than you'd expect

Some orders pay just a few dollars in base pay before tips. Riders across platforms consistently flag this as the first shock of the job. Budget your expectations around tip-inclusive totals, not base pay alone.

ACCEPTANCE RATE TRAP

On some platforms, declining too many low-paying orders can lower your acceptance rate and limit your ability to dash or deliver on demand, pushing you onto scheduled shifts only. Learn how your specific platform's acceptance rate actually works before you start declining orders freely.

☐ Sign-up delays are normal, not a sign something's wrong

Background checks and document verification can take days to weeks. Apply early if you're counting on this income by a specific date. Don't wait until you need the money immediately.

☐ Some hazards are genuinely unfamiliar at first

Dog encounters at delivery addresses come up often enough that experienced riders treat "beware of dog" signs as a hard stop. Call or text rather than approaching. In some cities, a meaningful share of delivery workers report being injured or assaulted on the job at some point. This isn't meant to scare you. It's meant to make sure you take it seriously from day one.

☐ Some buildings won't let you all the way in

Hospitals, secured apartment buildings, and office complexes often require you to leave orders at a front desk or wait for the customer to come down. You won't always be able to deliver to the door. This isn't a mistake on your part; it's just how those buildings operate.

☐ Gas and wear eat more of your pay than it feels like

Fuel alone can take a real bite out of gross earnings, and vehicle wear adds an invisible cost most new riders don't track until tax season. A high-MPG vehicle and a basic mileage log from week one will save you a financial surprise later.

Veteran Rider Reality Check

☐ Burnout creeps in differently than you'd expect

It's rarely one bad shift. It's the accumulation of long dead-time waits, penalties for things outside your control, and the physical toll of hours in a seat or on your feet. Veteran riders consistently name this, not pay, as the thing that eventually pushes them to quit or cut back.

☐ Pay can decline as the rider pool grows

As more drivers join a market, per-order pay in some areas has reportedly dropped, sometimes alongside falling order volume. This isn't something you did wrong; it's a market dynamic worth knowing so you can plan around it rather than blame yourself.

THE ALGORITHM ISN'T LOYAL

Multiple long-time riders report that newer accounts sometimes get better-paying offers than veteran accounts. There's no universal fix here, but knowing this dynamic exists can help you stop assuming you're doing something wrong when offers feel worse than they used to.

☐ Customer rating pressure rarely lets up

Strict rating systems and occasional unrealistic customer expectations are a near-universal veteran complaint. Many riders say they've effectively built their income around tips rather than base pay. Worth factoring into how you think about which orders to take.

☐ Health and accident risk compounds over years, not days

Repetitive strain, weather exposure, and accident risk are cumulative. A multi-year rider faces a different risk profile than someone three weeks in. Regular gear checks (helmet condition, brakes, tires) matter more the longer you do this, not less.

☐ You're carrying 100% of your own safety net

As a 1099 contractor, there's no built-in health insurance, workers' comp, or paid leave. Veteran riders consistently say this is the part that hits hardest after an injury or slow season. Worth researching independent contractor insurance options before you need them, not after.

Track mileage and expenses from day one. Most riders wish they'd started a simple spreadsheet sooner rather than reconstructing a year of receipts at tax time.

Every Platform, Same Hazards

CONDITIONS & RISK

☐ Weather cuts both ways

Bad weather sometimes raises per-order pay, but it also shrinks how many orders come through. A stormy shift can end up less profitable than a clear one, even with the bump. Good rain and cold gear isn't optional comfort; it's what makes a bad-weather shift survivable at all.

☐ Breakdowns happen at the worst times

Riders consistently mention fearing mechanical failure mid-shift, especially in winter. Keep basic emergency supplies (charged battery pack, jumper cables if driving, a spare tube if cycling) in your vehicle as standard practice, not an afterthought.

☐ Theft is a real, recurring risk

E-bike and order theft come up repeatedly in rider communities and local news coverage, particularly in dense urban areas. A heavy-duty lock and basic situational awareness when parking are worth the extra few seconds every single stop.

PEOPLE & POLICY

☐ Parking conflicts are a daily reality

Double-parking tickets and customer frustration over parking spots show up across every major platform's rider community. Know your city's specific delivery parking rules where they exist. Some cities have started carving out exceptions for delivery vehicles.

☐ Pay laws vary a lot by city

Cities including Seattle and New York have passed minimum base-pay rules for delivery workers in recent years, while other regions have no such floor. Know your local rules. They directly affect your minimum guaranteed pay and what protections you actually have.

☐ You're your own safety department

Platforms generally don't provide safety training or equipment. Whatever protective gear, lighting, or insurance you have is what you brought yourself. Plan accordingly rather than assuming a baseline is provided.

THE COMMON THREAD

None of this is platform-specific. It's the job itself. Whether you're on DoorDash, Uber Eats, Grubhub, or Instacart, the weather doesn't care which app you're logged into, and neither does a bad lock.

The Gear That Actually Earns Its Price

Across rider communities, the same gear regrets come up again and again. Here's what experienced riders say they wish they'd upgraded sooner, and why it actually matters, not just what's trendy.

	Real rain gear	A proper rain jacket and boots, not a thin poncho, are the difference between a manageable wet shift and calling it quits early. Riders who skimp here regret it the first real downpour.
	Insulated gloves	Cold, wet fingers are one of the most repeated complaints in winter riding. Riders consistently name gloves as the single gear upgrade they wish they'd made first, not last.
	Wool socks & lined boots	For sub-freezing shifts, dry feet matter as much as warm hands. Riders recommend always carrying a spare dry pair, not just wearing one good pair.
	A weatherproof phone mount	A cheap mount that fails mid-route doesn't just risk a dropped phone. It risks a missed delivery window. This is consistently flagged as a "buy once, buy right" item.
	A real insulated delivery bag	Cheap bags lose their seal and insulation fast. A thicker bag with a reliable zipper keeps food at the right temperature longer, which directly affects your ratings.
	A helmet that actually fits	For long shifts on a bike or scooter, comfort isn't vanity. An ill-fitting helmet gets removed or loosened, which defeats the purpose. Fit it properly once, wear it every time.
	A heavy-duty lock	Given how often bike and e-bike theft comes up in rider communities, a cheap cable lock is a false economy. This is one place where spending more upfront genuinely saves money later.



YOU'RE READY

Now go pick gear that actually earns its keep.

This checklist is the heads-up. Rider Complex's gear comparison tool is the next step. See real side-by-side breakdowns of helmets, gloves, cameras, and more, built specifically around what riders actually need in the field.

COMPARE GEAR AT RIDERCOMPLEX.COM

Visit ridercomplex.com/tools/gear-comparison to get started

